

A BOOK FOR CURIOUS YOUNG MINDS

The Light That Stays

*A Kid's Guide to Meditation and the Joy That Lives Inside
You*



MEIRA DAVIDSON

For the Jessica family kids — be curious, stay open, be kind.

FIRST EDITION

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The Light That Stays
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Written by Meira Davidson.

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Set in Iowan Old Style and Helvetica Neue.

A Note for the Grown-Up Reading Along

This is a book for young people — from about twelve onward, and just as readable for teenagers and grown-ups — about a simple, ancient idea: that there is a warm, awake, quietly joyful light inside each of us, and that we can learn to find it on purpose.

A few honest words before you hand it over.

Meditation is not a magic trick and it is not medicine. It helps a great many people feel steadier, kinder, and more able to enjoy small things — and there's good science behind that. But it is not a cure for everything. If a child in your life is carrying a sadness that won't lift, or thoughts that frighten them, the bravest and smartest thing is not to meditate harder — it's to tell a trusted grown-up: a parent, a teacher, a doctor, a counselor. Some feelings need a caring person, not just a cushion. You'll find that message gently repeated in the book itself, because I want every reader to hear it.

The practices and ideas in this book come from the Buddhist contemplative tradition — particularly the Zen and Tibetan Nyingma schools where I trained. You'll see that openly: a sutra or two, a mantra, a few names from the tradition. They're offered

here as universal tools, though; you don't have to be Buddhist, or anything else, for any of them to help. But you deserve to know where they come from.

Everything here is offered as a friend, not an authority. Use what helps. Leave the rest.

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CHAPTER 1

1

There's a Light in You, and It Doesn't Go Out



Right now, while you read this, something is reading.

Not your eyes — your eyes are just windows. Something *behind* your eyes is taking in these words and knowing them. That something has been with you your whole life. It was there when you were three years old and afraid of the dark. It's here now. It will be here tonight when you close your eyes.

We're going to spend this whole book getting to know that something. And here's the first surprise: it isn't a cold, blank, empty quiet. It's the most *alive* part of you — wide awake, and, strange as it sounds, quietly *glad*. People who've spent their lives looking for it come back saying the same odd thing: that deep down, underneath all the noise, there's a kind of brightness. Not a

brightness you could ever *see* — “bright” is just the closest word we have, the way we call a person “bright” when we mean wide awake and clear. It’s really more of a feeling: a quiet joy, the gladness of being awake for no reason at all.

The wonderful secret is this: **you already own it.** Nobody can take it. You don’t have to earn it or buy it or be good enough for it. It’s just there, waiting, like a sun that’s always shining even when clouds roll across it.

Now — a lot of books will tell you meditation is about getting calm. Calm is good, and we’ll practice it. But calm isn’t the treasure. Calm is just how you get the door open. Once it’s quiet enough inside, you start to notice the light that was there the whole time. That light — and the joy in it — is what this book is really about.

Meditation is simply how we walk back toward it.

This book will teach you how. We’ll start with stories — including one about a kid who was completely lost and found his way — and then I’ll hand you a small toolkit of things you can actually do, some of them in less than a minute, quietly, with nobody around you even noticing.

You don’t have to believe anything to begin. You just have to be a little curious.

CHAPTER 2

2

The Boy Who Got Lost (and a Different Way Out)



There's a scientist named Andrew Huberman. Today he's a professor at Stanford and millions of people listen to him explain how the brain works. But when he was a teenager, he was lost.

His parents got divorced when he was around thirteen, and after that his home felt unsteady and lonely. He stopped caring about school. He skipped classes so often that, in tenth grade, he ended up sent away to a place for kids who were getting into serious trouble. He'd fallen in with a crowd that drank, used drugs, and got into fights. From the outside, he looked like a kid throwing his future away.

Here's the part worth slowing down for. What turned him around was not luck, and it was not someone yelling at him to shape up.

It was **talking to someone** — a therapist, week after week, starting at that very program. It was **writing things down**, putting his messy thoughts onto paper until they got clearer. It was finding a few good people, mentors, who treated him like he was worth something. And somewhere along the way at that program, somebody handed him a book — a famous mindfulness book called *Wherever You Go, There You Are*, by Jon Kabat-Zinn. He's said it sparked an interest in meditation he's still carrying decades later. (You can read that same book yourself, by the way; it's still in print, and it's still good.)

Slowly, he came back to himself. He found a passion — first skateboarding, then, of all things, the brain — and he chased it all the way to becoming one of the most listened-to scientists alive.

I'm telling you his real story, not a polished fairy tale, for two reasons.

First: being lost is not the end. A kid who got removed from school became a Stanford professor. Where you are right now is not where you have to stay.

Second — and pay attention to this one: the thing that helped him most was *letting other people help him*. Talking. Being honest with a grown-up whose job was to listen. If you're carrying something heavy, the practices in this book can make you calmer — but they are not a substitute for telling a person you trust. The strongest, bravest people are the ones who ask for help. Huberman is proof.

He still sits, every day, for between five and eleven minutes. Think about that: the most listened-to scientist alive about brains and bodies has chosen, as his daily meditation, the kind of short, simple session anyone could do before breakfast. He sometimes adds an afternoon practice he calls *non-sleep deep rest* — different name, same family as what you're about to learn. The lost kid grew up to study, and to *live by*, the very quiet we're going to practice together. (For anyone curious for more, he's had a long meditation conversation with Sam Harris, one of the best-known meditation teachers alive.)

CHAPTER 3

3

My Own Long Walk Inward



For as far back as I can remember, I had a feeling about this whole world of practice that I can only call *recognition* — as if I were coming back to something rather than finding it for the first time. I don't know what to make of that, and you don't have to make anything of it either. But the pull was real, and it was there from when I was young.

I started reading about Buddhism in my mid-teens, and I just kept reading. Nobody was assigning anything. Mostly I read standing in the Buddhism aisle at the Barnes & Noble on Route 18, working my way through whatever was on the shelf. By my mid-twenties I'd been through most of it. The books I liked best were the memoirs of Westerners who had left their regular lives and gone east — to India, Nepal, the Himalayas — looking for a

teacher, or a cave, or some piece of themselves they couldn't find here. The whole *I was an ordinary American, then I walked into a monastery and didn't really come back* genre.

In the first few of those books I came across the idea of **reincarnation** — not in a fluffy way, but in the older, harder sense, that life keeps coming back around in every kind of body, and that the line between *me* and *the chicken on the plate* is not as clean as I'd been led to believe. Reading that, something just settled in me. I became a vegetarian that day. Not because anyone told me to and not because I had to argue myself into it. It just suddenly felt obvious. I've been one ever since.

I went on like that for years — reading, sitting sometimes in my room, nobody teaching me anything in particular. Mostly I was just longing and searching.

The Little Temple

When I was twenty-two, I found a small Buddhist temple not far from where I was going to graduate school. A monk had just moved to the area and started it, in the old Chinese tradition. The first time I walked in, the room smelled the way a temple smells — that mix of incense and old wood and quiet that I won't try to describe further, because if you've been in one you already know, and if you haven't, no words I write will get you there. The monk met me at the door. We clicked instantly — the way you sometimes meet a person and feel, with no good reason, that you already know them.

In his tradition, students call a teacher like this *Shifu* — the word means something close to *master* or *teacher*, the way Japanese students say *sensei*. So that's how I'll refer to him here: Shifu. He didn't tell me right away who he was — he wasn't the kind of person who told you, and it took me years to slowly piece it together. He was a respected scholar and the lineage holder of two ancient Zen monasteries, one of them in southeastern China and founded around the year 300 AD; seventeen hundred years of teachers had passed the practice down, hand to hand, to him. He had also spent years working at the side of one of the most important Chinese Buddhist figures of the twentieth century, helping to hold the tradition together through some of its hardest decades. He carried something very old and very alive, and he carried it without making any noise about it. By the time I met him, he was mostly interested in painting the house, watering the trees, and listening to whoever walked through the door.

What I want you to feel about him, more than the lineage, is this: there wasn't a particle of self-importance in him. He treated everyone exactly the same — Buddhist or not, regular or stranger off the street — with sincerity, respect, and his complete attention. He'd remember your name. He'd offer you tea. He'd ask how you were, and then he would actually listen to the answer. *That* — more than anything that happened on a cushion — was the meditation.

After I'd been a regular for a while, Shifu gave me a dharma name — a kind of spiritual name students of his tradition sometimes receive: 中禪. The character 禪 means *Zen* (the

meditation tradition itself), and 中 means *middle* or *center* — the same “middle” you find in the Buddhist idea of the **Middle Way**, the path that doesn’t lean too far in either direction.

And here’s the funny thing. Shifu barely “taught” me meditation in any formal way. Mostly he gave me jobs. *Water the trees today. Help paint the front of the house this Saturday.* I sat in on counseling sessions when people from the town came to him with their troubles, and I watched how he listened to them. I enjoyed all of it. I wasn’t restless about it or waiting for the *real* teaching to start; the work itself was peaceful. Only later did I understand that *that* was the teaching. The watering and the painting and the listening were the meditation, wearing work clothes.

The Path Opens

Somewhere in those years — whether Shifu nudged me toward it on purpose or whether it found me on its own, I’m honestly not sure — I came across the **Nyingma** school of Tibetan Buddhism, the older of the great Tibetan schools, founded by **Padmasambhava** (sometimes called Guru Rinpoche). I felt a pull toward it like nothing I’d felt before — toward its central teachings, and toward the way they point directly at the nature of mind. I went to a teaching retreat in North Carolina with a Nyingma teacher and a group of his longtime students. I sat. I listened. I came home and went on with my life.

One more honest thing about a long path. Teachers and students sometimes drift apart — for ordinary reasons, mostly. Communities form and break. Friendships in the dharma diverge. None of that has touched the practice itself, for me. **The teaching**

and the teacher are not the same thing, the same way a song and a singer are not the same thing. You can lose a singer and still keep the song.

Now

These days, decades on, the practice is just part of how I live — a daily routine like a morning walk or going to the gym. Nothing more than that, and on purpose. I sit when I have time. I don't think of it as a *spiritual pursuit*, and I'd gently steer you away from thinking of it that way too.

I'll tell you why, because I learned this one the hard way myself. For a long stretch I treated meditation as a spiritual pursuit — as a *somewhere I was going*, an attainment, a level. Looking back from where I am now, that orientation didn't serve me. The only setup where meditation honestly becomes the central thing in a life is monastic — ordination as a monk or nun in a real tradition. That is a real path, and the people who walk it offer something the rest of the world quietly needs. It just isn't my path; I have never had a calling to monastic life.

For everyone else — almost everyone — meditation works best when you keep it small. A daily thing, like a walk or going to the gym, that makes life a little clearer and a little kinder, and then you go live the rest of your life.

If there is one thing in this whole chapter I most want you to take away, it is this: **don't make meditation a special thing. Make it a small, daily thing.** Just sit, the way you would just walk, or just lift weights. Live the rest of your life with both hands. The

practice will quietly change you in the background; it doesn't need you to chase it. It just needs you to show up most days — and then go do everything else.

(After this many years, my own body has settled into a cross-legged seat that's comfortable for me. Please don't read anything into that. It's just what one body happened to settle into over time. Plenty of people who've practiced just as long sit in chairs. Yours is yours. Find what lets you sit easy and forget about it.)

The little temple is still my home base. I still go back when I can. I still show up there for Buddhist holidays. Some things you build early in your life become the thread that pulls you home for the rest of it. That little temple is mine.

I'm not telling you any of this so you'll do exactly what I did. Your path will be your own, and it should be. I'm telling you because I want you to know that this stuff is *real* in an ordinary life — not only in books, and not only in monasteries. It started with a curious teenager and a cushion in her bedroom. It can start with you, exactly where you are.

CHAPTER 4

4

Once You See It, You Can't Unsee It



So what happens if you keep at it?

Meditation doesn't make life's hard things disappear; nothing can do that. What it does is stranger, and better.

At some point, if you keep practicing, you get a *peek*. Not at a quiet, empty stillness — at something more alive than that. The part of you that's just *aware*, underneath all the noise, turns out to carry a kind of wakeful brightness and a quiet, causeless gladness. Not gladness *about* anything. Just gladness, the kind that doesn't need a reason. People call this catching a glimpse of "the nature of your mind." It's hard to describe — like trying to explain the color blue to someone who's never seen it. But here's what I can

promise: **once you've felt it, you can't unfeel it.** You'll know, forever, that it's there — even on the days the clouds cover it completely.

And it changes you. Quietly, from the inside.

You start to feel that every living thing — every person, every animal, every annoying classmate, every stranger — has the same nature of mind that you do. They're not you, of course. They have their own lives, their own hopes, their own hurts; they want to be happy as much as you do. But the awake, knowing quality underneath all of that — the same watcher we've been finding inside you all through this book — is also inside them. Same nature, different lives. And once you really feel that, cruelty stops making sense. How could you be cruel to a being who, underneath everything, is reaching for the same things you're reaching for, made of the same wakeful stuff? You find yourself caring about others almost without trying.

You also get tougher in a soft way. When something goes wrong, you don't get knocked over as easily, because you're standing on something that bad days can't reach. And you start to notice small joys you used to walk right past — a flower at the edge of the sidewalk, a dog tilting its head when you say its name, the smell of something good cooking, the warmth of sun on your shoulders, a stranger's small kindness on a bus, a tree on your street suddenly looking beautiful, a piece of food you actually *taste* instead of just swallow, a friend laughing, a good breath. They were always there. They're everywhere, honestly — and a practice is what slowly trains your eyes to see them again.

I say *slowly* on purpose, because I want to be honest with you. If life has been heavy for a while, you may already have noticed that the things people say should bring joy don't seem to anymore. The food doesn't taste like much. The flowers don't really land. The thing that used to make you laugh still makes you smile, but only for a second. That isn't because the joys aren't there. It's because heaviness puts a kind of film over your eyes, and the film takes time to come off.

So try this — gently. Keep your short daily practice going — the breath-watching, the body scan, the one-minute reset, whatever's become yours — even when it doesn't feel like it's doing anything. And turn back toward whatever used to bring you the most joy — but not by sitting around doing nothing. When you're already heavy, that kind of empty, inert time tends to deepen the weight. Reach instead for things that actually engage you. They can be quiet or loud, fast or slow, as long as they really pull you in: dancing to a song you love, playing with your dog, calling a friend who makes you feel like yourself, rock climbing, a math puzzle you couldn't put down, a sport you used to play hard, running, swimming, biking, drawing, building something, a book that grips you so hard you forget the time. Whatever used to light you up.

One I want to single out, because almost nothing else on earth shifts a heavy mood as reliably: moving your body, hard enough to get sweaty. Tennis or pickleball with one other person, a long bike ride, swimming until your arms are tired, a walk that turns into a run. The science behind this is solid and the effect is real — exercise is one of the most underrated things you can do for your mind, not just your body. (Team sports work too, of course — but

they need a whole group of playmates, and if your usual crowd has gone strange on you, finding one can be its own hill to climb. Better to start with something that needs only you, or just one other person who's still around for you.) The opposite of heaviness isn't *loud* — it's *engaged*. A math puzzle is quiet from outside but very alive inside. That counts. What doesn't help is the doing-nothing, sitting-around kind of time.

Let yourself stay with it a little longer than feels normal. There's a voice inside heaviness that whispers *yeah, but you don't really feel it anymore* — and that voice is part of the film, not the truth. The thing you loved is still there. Stay with it anyway. Slowly the film thins. The flower lands. The dog's head-tilt is funny again. Hard times don't get the last word in a life that keeps practicing — and slowly, you find yourself meeting them with a kind of stubborn, gentle optimism.

That — not relaxation, not being good at sitting still — is the *whole point* of meditation. Everything else is just practice for this.

CHAPTER 5

5

How to Sit — Your Body Is the Foundation



Before we ask the big question — *who is seeing?* — we have to do something first. We have to *sit*.

This is the part most meditation books skip, and skipping it is exactly why so many people try meditation, feel nothing, and quit. Here's the secret nobody told them: **you can't bully your mind into being calm. But you can arrange your body — and the mind quietly follows.**

There's an old image I love. Your mind is like a rider, and your breath is the horse it rides on. Where the horse goes, the rider goes. If the horse is bucking and galloping, the rider gets bounced all over the place. But if the horse slows to a gentle walk, the rider settles right down. Your breath is that horse — and the way you *sit*

decides how the horse moves. Slump over and squash your lungs, and the breath turns short and jumpy, and so does your mind. Sit tall and open, and the breath grows long and smooth, and the mind grows calm and bright almost by itself.

So we start with the body. Always the body first.

The Seven Points of a Good Seat

Long ago, meditators worked out seven small adjustments that turn your body into a steady, comfortable seat — like a cup that can hold still water without spilling it. You don't have to be bendy or athletic. You just line up these seven points and let the rest go.

1. Your legs — cross them, and build a wide, steady base. The most famous pose is the **lotus**, where each foot rests up on the opposite thigh. It makes a beautiful, rock-solid triangle, like a little mountain that can't tip over. If it's comfortable for you, wonderful.

But listen closely, because this part matters: **never force it**. Your body is still growing, and jamming your knees down into a full lotus can injure them for real. There is no prize for a hurt knee. A half-lotus (just one foot up) is great. Plain cross-legged is great. Kneeling with a cushion is great. And sitting in a **chair** with your feet flat on the floor is completely, totally fine — plenty of lifelong meditators sit in chairs. The pose only exists to keep you steady. It is *not* the meditation.

One thing that's actually important enough that I should stop calling it a "trick": **put a cushion under your butt**. Sit on the front edge of a firm cushion, a folded blanket, or even a stack of pillows — anything that lifts your hips a couple of inches above your knees. This is the move that lets your spine stay straight without

you having to fight for it. With a little practice you'll find your own right height; most people land somewhere between two and five inches. Without that lift, almost everyone slumps or strains. With it, the posture nearly holds itself.

2. Your hands — let them rest. Either lay them palms-down on your knees, or rest them in your lap, one hand cupped in the other, thumbs barely touching to make a soft oval. Then forget about them. Let them be heavy.

3. Your spine — straight, like a stack of coins. This is the master key. If you remember only one point on this whole list, remember this one. Picture your backbone as a tall stack of coins, each balanced right on the one below. The whole spine should feel long, as if a soft string were attached to the very top of your head, gently lifting it upward — the crown of your head floating at the highest point of you, like a balloon held up by a thread from above. *And then — relax. Really, relax.* Straight but not stiff. Tall but not tense. Everything soft except that one quiet thread of upward lift. Here's the practical move that actually gets your crown to that high, balanced spot: the small chin tuck in point 5 below. That tiny tuck does almost all the work. Get those two right — long spine, chin tucked, crown lifting on its own — and the rest more or less take care of themselves: the shoulders drop, the head balances, the breath travels all the way down. The whole posture sits itself.

4. Your shoulders — open, like a bird's wings. Roll them gently back and let them drop. The old teachers said to open the chest "like a vulture spreading its wings." It just means: don't hunch. Let the space around your heart be open.

5. Your chin — tucked just a little. Small but secretly important — this is the move that makes point 3 actually work. Drop your chin a tiny bit, like a small hook, so the back of your neck grows long. Not chin-on-chest — just the slightest tuck. With it, the head balances right on top of the spine and the crown floats up to the highest point of you all on its own. Without it, the head tends to poke forward and the whole posture droops with it. So small, so important: tuck the chin a little, and your spine does the rest.

6. Your eyes — soft, and (if you like) a little open. Here's a surprise: you don't have to shut your eyes. Many traditions — including the one closest to my own heart — keep the eyes slightly open, gaze soft and lowered, resting on a spot on the floor a few feet ahead without really looking at anything. Open eyes keep you from drifting off to sleep. If open feels too busy while you're learning, close them — that's fine too. Soft, either way.

7. Your mouth — relaxed, tongue resting up. Let your lips and teeth come slightly apart, soft, almost a hint of a smile. Rest the tip of your tongue gently on the ridge just behind your upper front teeth. Then breathe through your nose, naturally. Don't *do* anything to the breath yet. Just let it come and go.

Seven points. Run through them once at the start, top to bottom — then *leave your body alone*. You're not a soldier standing at attention. You're a mountain that has found its balance and can sit, easy and awake, for a long, long time.

One thing to underline before we move on: **don't stress your body trying to do all seven of these**. The two that matter most are the **spine** and the **chin tuck**. Get those right, and the others mostly fall into place on their own. Everything past that — *relax*. If you

find yourself gripping or straining to hold the posture, you've already lost the thread. The seat is not one more thing to be good at; it is just the shape that lets you let go.

The Body Scan — Settling In, Breath by Breath

Now that you're sitting well, here is the practice I'd put in your hands first if I could give you only one. It's called a **body scan**, and it trains your body and your breath to settle down together. Read it through once, then try it. Ten minutes is plenty. Even three is real.

Arrive. In your seven points, take three slow, deliberate breaths: in through the nose, then a long, slow breath out through the mouth, like you're gently fogging a mirror. With each out-breath, let your whole body grow a little heavier, a little softer. After the third one, let the breath go back to normal, in and out through the nose. You don't steer it now. You just *watch* it, the way you'd watch waves roll in and slide back out.

Now travel slowly down through your body, riding the breath.

- Bring your attention to the very top of your head. Breathe in and *shine* your attention there, like a soft flashlight. Breathe out, and let the top of your head soften.
- Slide the light down to your face. Forehead — let it smooth. Eyes — let them grow heavy. Jaw — this one's sneaky; we clench it without knowing. Breathe out and let your jaw come loose.
- Down to your neck and shoulders. Almost everyone carries their whole day right here. Breathe in, notice them — then on

the out-breath, let them *drop*, lower and looser than you thought they could go.

- Down your arms — upper arms, elbows, forearms, all the way to your hands. Notice your hands. Maybe warm, maybe tingly, maybe heavy, maybe nothing much. Whatever's there is fine. You're not making a feeling happen. You're just noticing what's already there.
- Into your chest. Feel it rise and fall on its own. You don't lift it. It breathes *you*.
- Into your belly. Let it go soft, moving with the breath like a balloon gently filling and emptying.
- Down your back, one coin of the spine at a time. Strong and easy.
- Into your hips, sitting heavy. Feel the ground holding you up. You don't have to hold yourself — the earth's got you.
- Down your legs — thighs, knees, shins — to your feet. Feel your feet. Feel exactly where they touch the floor.

Here's the part that turns this from a nap into meditation.

Resting there, feeling your whole body at once, gently ask: *Who is feeling all of this?* The warmth in the hands, the rise of the chest, the weight of sitting — someone is aware of every bit of it. That someone is *you* — not the sensations, but the one who *knows* them. Don't strain for an answer. Just let the question turn your attention back toward the quiet one who's been watching all along. (That's the big question of the next chapter — and look, you're already standing at its door.)

Rest. For a last little while, stop traveling. Just sit, breathing, whole. Body settled, breath slow — the rider quiet now, on a horse that's slowed to a gentle walk. Nothing to do, nowhere to be. Stay as long as it stays easy. Then open your eyes the rest of the way and carry a thread of that stillness out into your day.

Ending with a Small Dedication

There's one more piece I love to add at the very end of any formal sit, just before you open your eyes. It takes a few seconds, and it quietly changes the whole practice.

Before you get up, take one more slow breath, and send out a wish — the way you'd wish on a falling star. The wish can be anything, as long as it's kind. You can wish for someone you love (*may my mom be happy*). You can wish for yourself (*may I be gentle with myself today*). You can wish for people you don't even know (*may anyone having a hard day feel held*). You can wish for the whole world (*may it be a little gentler tomorrow*). You can wish for a cause you care about (*may more kids have books to read, may fewer animals be hurt*).

The wish doesn't do anything magical out in the world. What it does is point your heart outward for a moment, before you stand up. The meditation built up something quiet and good inside you; the wish is how you give a little of it away. A practice that ends in a wish, over the years, builds a person who's *bigger* of heart, not smaller.

One breath, one wish, one quiet *may this be so*, and you're done.

The Three-Breath Version (for busy days)

No ten minutes today? Sit up — spine like coins. Take three slow breaths, and with each one, drop your shoulders, soften your jaw, and feel your feet on the floor. That's a real meditation. Tiny is still real.

CHAPTER 6

6

The Big Question, and the Surprise Behind It



This is the most important chapter in the book. It starts with a riddle and ends with a surprise. Stay with me.

There's an old, old teaching from a text called the **Shurangama Sutra**. In it, a teacher walks a confused student through one simple, mind-bending point. I'll put it in everyday words:

Everything you can see, hear, feel, or think about — none of that is the real you. The real you is the one doing the seeing, the hearing, the feeling, the thinking.

Let's test it on yourself, right now.

- Look at your hand. You can see your hand — so your hand is a *thing you see*. It's not the seer. The seer is behind your eyes, watching the hand.
- Now notice a sound in the room. The sound is a *thing you hear*. You are the one hearing it.
- Now notice a thought floating by — maybe "*this is weird*" or "*I'm hungry*." That thought is a *thing you noticed*. So you can't be the thought. You're the one who *caught* it going by.

Do you feel the trick of it? Everything you can point to — your body, your feelings, your thoughts, the whole world — is something you're *aware of*. So none of it can be the awareness itself. **You are the awareness.** The one watching. The one who was here before the thought arrived and is still here after it leaves.

Most books stop right here. This one keeps going — because finding the watcher is only half the discovery. The other half is finding out *what the watcher is like*. And it's not what almost everyone expects.

The Surprise

You might guess that this pure awareness, this "watcher," is a cold, blank, empty kind of quiet. A nothing. An empty room with the lights off.

It's the opposite. When you stop chasing thoughts and actually *rest* as that awareness — not think *about* it, just sit *in* it — three things show up. They're hard to say in words, so I'll give you pictures.

One — you look for it, and you can't find a thing. (That's the first clue, not a problem.) Try to find the watcher. Where is it? What color? How big? You come up empty — there's no *object* there to grab, no shape, no edges, no weight. The old teachers called this being "empty." But careful: not empty like a sad, dark nothing. Empty like the *open sky* — empty the way a room is empty when there's *space for anything* to happen in it.

Two — and yet it is wide awake. It *knows*. Here's the strange part. Even though you can't find any *thing*, you can't call it nothing either — because *it is knowing all of this, right now*. Something in there is awake. Something is alert enough to be reading these very words and understanding them as they pass. Think of a clear mirror. A mirror holds no picture of its own — it's "empty," it isn't keeping anything — and yet it's not blank or dead. It's perfectly *clear*, and so it can show a whole world exactly as it is. Your awareness is like that: empty of any fixed thing, but clear, awake, alive, always knowing. People sometimes call this clear, knowing quality the "**light**" of the mind — and here I have to be careful with you, because that word fools almost everyone. *There is no actual light*. It is not a glow you could ever see. If you go hunting behind your eyes for some inner brightness, you've simply turned awareness into one more *thing* you're aware of — and we already said it can never be a thing. "Light" is just the word we reach for because *knowing* feels lucid and awake, the way a clear morning feels clear. It points at a feeling, not a lamp.

Three — and underneath, there's a joy that doesn't come from anywhere. This is the part I most want you to find for yourself, because it's the part that changes everything. Think about how happiness usually works. You're happy *because* of something

— a gift, a friend, a good grade, a win. Which means the moment the thing goes away, the happy goes with it. That kind of joy is always *on loan*; you're always about to have to give it back. But there's another kind. Have you ever, just for a second, felt glad to be alive for *no reason at all*? Nothing happened — just a quiet, easy gladness, a small *yes* somewhere in you. Most people get tiny flashes of it and never even notice. That gladness isn't arriving from anything outside you. It's the gladness of awareness itself — not gladness *about* anything, just the light, easy feeling of being awake at all. (Notice that word *light* again — I don't mean a glow. I mean *light* the way a weight lifting off you feels light.) And here's the world-changing part: because nothing *causes* it, **nothing can take it away**. You can lose the gift, flunk the grade, lose the game — and that quiet gladness is still there underneath, the way the sky is still there behind the clouds. It never went anywhere. The clouds just hid it for a while.

So the watcher you went looking for is not a cold, empty quiet. It is **empty, wide awake, and quietly joyful — all at once, all one thing**. Empty the way open sky is empty. Awake the way a clear, rested mind is awake. Joyful the way you feel when, for no reason at all, you're simply glad to be here. Not one of those three is a sight or a sound or a thing you could point to — they're the *texture of awareness itself*, which is exactly why no word, not even "light," ever quite lands on it. The words are only fingers pointing at the moon. Don't stare at the finger.

That is the nature of your mind. That's what all the old books, in all the old languages, keep circling around and pointing at. And now you know what I meant back in Chapter 1: once you've truly

met it — even for one second — you can't unmeet it. You will know, for the rest of your life, that beneath every single bad day there is a quiet gladness that nothing can switch off.

Why This Is the Secret Engine of Everything

Once you've felt even a flicker of that, the way you hold your whole life loosens.

Here's how I think about it as a grown-up. All the outside stuff — the labels, the grades, the followers, the things people swear are "important" — is *on loan*, exactly like borrowed happiness. It's a bunch of *symbols*, and symbols can flip in a minute. I won't lie and say seeing this makes life perfect: I can't snap my fingers and put a million dollars in my bank account and retire just because I understand it. But what *does* happen is that I can look at things clearly. My feelings stop bossing my judgment around. The light underneath doesn't flicker just because the symbols changed.

And notice — the calm that comes from this isn't me gritting my teeth and forcing myself not to care. It grows on its own, out of *understanding*. When you really see how something works — that it was always on loan, that it was never the light — your grip on it just relaxes. You don't have to pry your fingers open one by one. They open by themselves.

That's the engine of this whole book. Everything else — the breathing, the pictures, the sitting still — is here to walk you back, again and again, to that empty-bright-warm watcher, until "Who is seeing?" stops being a riddle and becomes the most familiar friend you'll ever have.

CHAPTER 7

7

The One-Minute Practice (Start Absurdly Small)



Here's the most important rule of meditation, and almost nobody says it out loud:

A tiny bit every day beats a lot once in a while.

Five minutes a day, every day, will change you more than an hour once a month. So we start small. So small it feels silly. So small you have *no excuse*.

The One-Minute Reset

You can do this anywhere — in class, on the bus, before a test, in the middle of an argument. Nobody will even know.

1. Stop. Wherever you are, just stop for one minute. The whole secret is in the stopping.
2. Drop your shoulders. Unclench your jaw. Feel your feet on the floor, or your weight in the chair.
3. Now just *watch* your breath. Don't change it, don't push it — only notice it. A slow breath in. A slower breath out. Let your mind ride along with the breath, the way you'd watch waves roll in and slide back out.
4. As you watch, feel your body breathing — the small rise, the soft fall, the tiny pauses in between. Let the breathing do itself. You don't have to help.
5. Rest there until the minute is up. Then go back to your day.

You aren't doing anything fancy. You're just letting your mind settle onto the breath and your body, and resting there for sixty seconds. The rest comes naturally once the mind has somewhere kind to land.

One minute. That's the whole thing. If that's all you ever do, you're meditating.

Building the Daily Habit

Pick a time you already do something every single day — brushing your teeth, getting into bed, sitting down for breakfast. Park your meditation right next to it. “After I brush my teeth at night, I sit for five minutes.” Tying a new habit to an old one is the oldest trick in the book, and it works.

Don’t aim for thirty minutes on day one. Aim for *showing up*. Some days you’ll sit for five minutes and feel nothing. Sit anyway. You’re not collecting good sessions — you’re building a road, one step at a time, back toward the light inside you.

Short and Often Beats Long and Rare

Remember the scientist from Chapter 2? He still sits for five to eleven minutes a day. Not an hour. Not even thirty minutes. Five to eleven minutes, every day, for years. That’s not him being lazy — that’s him being *smart*.

The most effective meditation practice in the world isn’t long; it is **short and often**. Five minutes every day will change you far more than an hour once a month. Two minutes twice a day beats nothing for a week followed by twenty minutes on Sunday because you felt guilty. Your nervous system learns from gentle repetition, not from heroic single sessions.

So pick a length so small you’d be a little embarrassed to call it meditation, and do *that*. Five minutes. Three minutes. The one-minute reset on a busy day. Tiny is still real. Tiny *every day* is what changes you. If you ever want to do more on a calm day, fine — but the daily short sit is the engine. The long ones are just a bonus.

Always End with a Wish

At the end of every formal sit, send out a small kind wish before you open your eyes — that little dedication from Chapter 5. Don't skip it.

It can be tiny. *May my mom have a good day. May I be patient today. May the kid having a hard time at school feel a little less alone.* Whatever's kind. It can be light, even silly. It does not have to be deep — just kind.

The wish takes three seconds. Without it, meditation stays a private thing — something you do for yourself that stays inside you. The wish points your heart outward right before you stand up. Years of small wishes, at the ends of small sits, quietly turn into a bigger heart almost by accident.

So: every time. Even on the days you don't feel like it. *Especially* then.

Never Force It — and When to Stop

This is one of the most important rules in this whole book: **don't force the practice. Ever.** Life is too short to add another hassle that stresses you out. If meditation ever starts to feel like one more chore on your list — one more thing to be bad at — something has gone wrong with how you're doing it, not with you. Back off. Make it smaller. Make it kinder. Or skip a day. The cushion isn't going anywhere.

Meditation is not a workout where you push through the burn. It's the opposite. The moment you start gritting your teeth, white-knuckling, trying to *make* yourself stay calm — you've already lost the thread. Calm doesn't come from squeezing harder. It comes from letting go.

And here's a real thing nobody warns beginners about: sometimes when you sit quietly, **big feelings come up**. Sadness you didn't know was there. Anger from something old. Tears, even, with no obvious cause. The noise of the day usually drowns those feelings out; in the quiet, they finally get a chance to be heard. That isn't the practice failing. It's the practice working. Most days, the right move is to just notice the feeling kindly, let it be there, and stay with the breath.

But if a feeling ever gets too big — if you feel overwhelmed, flooded, panicky, or just *too much* — **stop**. Open your eyes. Stand up. Get a glass of water. Don't try to push through. Pushing through is how meditation turns into something harmful instead of something helpful.

Then turn toward one of the engaged activities from Chapter 4 — the ones that quietly carry joy into you when nothing else can. Dance to a song you love. Take a walk. Call a friend. Work a math puzzle. Draw something. Ride your bike. Play with your dog. Pick up the book you've been reading. *Do something with the world for a while*. The cushion will still be there tomorrow.

And if the big feelings keep coming back day after day, or feel too heavy to carry alone — please remember what the lost boy in Chapter 2 did. He talked to someone whose job was to listen. Tell a grown-up you trust. That isn't weakness. It is one of the strongest, kindest moves a person can make for themselves.

CHAPTER 8

8

Breathing — Telling Your Body You're Safe



Here's something amazing that scientists (including the one from Chapter 2) have shown: **the way you breathe sends a message straight to your brain.** Fast, shallow breathing tells your brain *we're in danger!* Slow breathing tells it *we're safe, you can relax now.* Your breath is like a remote control for how calm or jumpy you feel.

You don't have to believe me. Try them.

One thing before you do: feel free to skip the counting if it stresses you out. The numbers below are guides, not rules. The real secret of every breath practice in this chapter is one simple thing — **make your out-breath longer than your in-breath, and let it all slow down.** Whether your in-breath is two seconds or

five, whether your out-breath is twice as long or three times as long, none of that really matters. Just slower out than in, and slower than your usual breathing. If counting helps you stay with the rhythm, count. If counting itself makes you tense, drop it. Watch the breath, lengthen the out, and let the rhythm find itself.

The Long Goodbye (the calmer)

Breathe in for a count of 4. Breathe *out* for a count of 8. The trick is making the out-breath longer than the in-breath. That long, slow exhale is the part that flips your body into calm. Do this five or six times when you feel nervous or upset.

The Double Breath (the fast reset)

Take a normal breath in through your nose — then, before letting it out, sneak in one more little sip of air to top off your lungs. Now let it all out slowly through your mouth, like fogging a window. Two or three of these can settle you down in seconds. (This is the one Huberman talks about as a scientist.)

Square Breathing (the focuser)

Trace a square in your mind. Breathe in for 4 (up the side). Hold for 4 (across the top). Out for 4 (down the side). Hold for 4 (across the bottom). Round and round the square. Great before a test or a game.

Notice what's actually happening when you do any of these. You're not really *doing* the breathing — your body has been breathing all day, all by itself, whether you noticed or not. What you're really doing is *watching* — feeling the air at your nostrils,

feeling your chest rise and fall, feeling your belly soften, feeling the small pause at the top of each breath and the slightly longer one at the bottom. The closer you get to the actual sensations, the more your body settles, all on its own. That's the real secret none of these techniques can tell you by themselves: **the slowing doesn't come from effort. It comes from attention.** The breath has been waiting for you to notice it. The moment you do, the body knows you've come home, and it lets go.

And there's that watcher again — the one we've been finding all through this book. You can't do a breathing exercise without it. The breath is in front; the one feeling it is, as always, you.

CHAPTER 9

9

Picturing It — Visualization



Your imagination is powerful. Meditation can use it on purpose. Here are a few pictures to try while you sit with your eyes closed.

The Sky and the Sun

Imagine your mind is a huge, wide-open sky. Your thoughts and feelings are clouds and storms drifting across it — some dark, some fluffy and bright. You don't chase them or push them away. You just watch them pass. You're not the weather. *You're the sky.*

But don't stop at empty sky. Remember Chapter 6: high above all the clouds, the **sun** is always shining — warm, bright, never once switched off. The storms can hide it, but they can't put it out. That sun stands for the joy and wakefulness that are your real

nature — a picture to lean on while you practice, not a real light to go find. On a hard day, picture the clouds rolling in front of it, and then remember: the sun didn't go anywhere. It's still up there, warming the top of every cloud. This one picture can carry you through a whole lifetime of hard days.

Your Favorite Place in Nature

Now picture, somewhere in the world, a place in nature where you feel completely at peace. Maybe it's a beach you've been to once. A meadow. A trail in the woods behind your house. A place from a book or a movie. Real or imagined — it doesn't matter, as long as it feels like *yours*.

For me, my place is the top of a tropical mountain at night. The sky above me is full of stars — more than I usually see, every one of them clear and bright. Far below, the dark ocean stretches out to the horizon, boundless. The air is soft and warm. Nothing in the world needs me. I'm just there, sitting, held by the dark sky and the wide world.

Find your version of that. Build it in your mind. Notice the sky, the ground, the air on your skin, the sounds in the distance. Sit there in your meditation as if you were sitting there in person. Let the place hold you. The body in your room and the body in that place are doing the same thing — being still, being held. That's the whole point.

Sitting on a Lotus

Here's one more picture for your sit. Imagine, underneath you as you meditate, a giant lotus flower has opened. Its broad, soft pink petals are spread wide like a great cushion, and you're sitting right in the middle, held up by the bloom.

Here's why the lotus is the perfect image. The lotus grows in *mud*. Its roots are buried deep in the muck at the bottom of a pond — dark, slimy, ordinary. But somehow the stem rises up through the murky water, breaks the surface, and opens into a clean, perfect flower in the sun. The mud doesn't ruin it. In fact, the lotus *can't* bloom without the mud. The flower and the muck are part of the same plant.

That's a picture of you. Your life has its mud — the hard days, the rejections, the messes you didn't ask for and didn't choose. The lotus doesn't pretend the mud isn't there. It just keeps growing up through it, and what blooms at the top is the open, awake, kind person you're already becoming. Sit on the lotus. Let the mud be the mud. Bloom anyway.

And here's a beautiful thing you can do once you're seated on your lotus. Imagine, just above the crown of your head, a soft rainbow light. As you breathe in, that light begins to pour gently in through the top of your head — *inside* you, not over you — and flows slowly down through the middle of your body, all the way to your feet: through your face, your neck, your chest, your belly, your hips, your legs.

Picture the light carrying away whatever heaviness you've been holding: tiredness, worry, the ache of a hard day, sadness that's been sitting on your chest, an argument you keep replaying in

your head. As it flows down through you, the light dissolves it all and carries it down — out the bottom, through the lotus, into the mud where the roots are. Even your hardest stuff becomes nourishment for the bloom. By the time the light has reached your feet, you feel cleaner, lighter, refreshed.

You don't have to believe in any of this for it to work. You're just using your imagination to help your body let go and your heart open.

The Warm Light

Imagine a soft, warm light glowing in the center of your chest. With each breath, it grows a little brighter and spreads a little wider — out through your whole body, then out to your family, your friends, even people you find difficult, until it fills the whole room and beyond. This is an old way of growing kindness on purpose. (It connects to what we said in Chapter 4: that the same light is in everyone.)

Mix Them Together

These pictures aren't four separate exercises — they're different doors into the same room, and you can walk through several at once. Picture yourself sitting in your favorite place in nature — your beach, your meadow, the top of your mountain. Now imagine a great lotus has opened up underneath you, holding you up off the ground. And from just above the crown of your head, the rainbow light begins to pour down through you, carrying away whatever heaviness you brought to the cushion. That's the

fullest version: the place holds you, the lotus holds you up, the light moves through. You don't have to do all of it every time — some days one door is enough. Whatever feels right.

The pictures themselves don't matter. The *feeling* matters: peace, serenity, a body that's let go of something it had been carrying, a small refreshed glow when you open your eyes. If you sit for ten minutes and come back with a little of that — by whatever door — the visualization worked.

Letting the Picture Go

After a while, let the picture fade and just rest in the quiet that's left. The pictures are training wheels. The real ride is the stillness underneath.

CHAPTER 10

10

Mindfulness — The View from the Eagle



The past mind cannot be grasped. The present mind cannot be grasped. The future mind cannot be grasped. — from the Diamond Sutra

There's an old, old line — more than fifteen hundred years old — that sounds like a riddle. *The past mind can't be grabbed. The present mind can't be grabbed. The future mind can't be grabbed.* What is that supposed to mean? Stay with it for a minute, because it has something important to say about a word you've probably heard a hundred times by now: **mindfulness**.

It's everywhere. Mindfulness apps on your phone. Mindfulness classes at school. Companies sending their employees to mindfulness workshops. Famous people swearing by it — Jerry Seinfeld has talked for decades about how Transcendental Meditation changed his life; Ray Dalio, one of the most successful investors alive, says it's the single most valuable thing he's ever learned. A whole movement has formed around a practice that used to belong to a few quiet people in caves.

In many ways that's wonderful. But it's also meant the word has gotten flattened. Most people now think mindfulness means *try harder to focus*, or *force your mind to stay in the present*. One more thing on your to-do list. One more thing you're failing at. If that's what mindfulness sounded like to you, no wonder you weren't excited about it.

Real mindfulness is the opposite of that. Real mindfulness is *lighter*, not heavier.

The Eagle and the Hallway

Here's a picture that gets at it. Imagine it's the worst kind of Tuesday at school. You're walking through the crowded hallway between classes, and there's something bad sitting on top of your whole day — somebody said something cruel, your best friend was strange with you at lunch, you bombed a quiz, the group chat went silent the second you sent your message. From the hallway it feels *enormous*. It fills your entire life. You can't see past it. Every face streaming by seems to know.

Now imagine an eagle lifts off from beside you and rises straight up — through the ceiling, through the roof, up above the school — until from way up there it can see the whole town. Your school is one small building in a wide, green landscape. Your hallway is one corridor inside that small building. The thing that was crushing you is still down there, but now it's one tiny piece of one small building in a wide, beautiful world. From up here you can also see the road home, your street, the trees in your yard, the river out past the highway, the sun that will rise over all of it tomorrow.

Mindfulness is what happens when you become, for a moment, the eagle. You don't leave your life. You just stop being *pinned* to one square inch of it. You see your situation from a wider sky. From up there, things stop being life-or-death. You stop *clinging* to your one fixed point of view, your one story about what's happening. You can see other angles. You can guess how you'll feel about this in a week, or a year, or five years. The crisis becomes part of a much larger picture.

That is what the Diamond Sutra meant. The past, present, and future "mind" can't be *grabbed* because there's nothing solid there to grab. The moment you reach out to seize *now*, it's already gone. The past is gone. The future hasn't shown up. There's nothing to clutch. And — surprising no one more than yourself — once you stop trying to clutch, the whole thing gets lighter.

When the Mind Gets Stuck

Here's something worth knowing about how the mind works, because once you see it you can never quite unsee it. A lot of the worst suffering in life doesn't come from the original bad thing —

it comes from the way the mind keeps *coming back* to the bad thing. Someone says something cruel at school. You walk away. The cruel thing is over, factually. But your mind plays it again. And again. And every replay makes the groove a little deeper and the feeling a little bigger, until you've spun ten bad seconds into a whole bad week.

Everyone does this. Watch the adults around you — you'll see it everywhere, sometimes painfully so. The mind has a strange habit of latching onto a problem and looping it like a stuck song, and the more it loops, the more *real* and *huge* and *permanent* the problem feels. The loop itself becomes the trap. The mind, in trying to solve the thing, ends up reinforcing the thing — a vicious circle that keeps tightening on the very person caught in it. People can spend years inside a loop like that without ever quite realizing the loop is what's keeping them there, not the original hurt.

This is exactly where the eagle helps.

When the eagle lifts off, you stop being the one *inside* the loop and become, for a moment, the one *watching* it. The hurt is still down there, but you're not living inside it — you're observing it from above, the way you'd watch a good friend going through something hard. And something quiet happens when you watch from outside: most of the emotional fog burns off. You can think clearly again. You can see angles you couldn't see while you were tangled up inside. You can ask the question that the loop never lets you ask: *is this actually as huge as it feels right now, or am I making it huger every time I run through it?* Sometimes you notice — with a little surprise — that the problem looks different from up here than it did down there.

The eagle doesn't make the hard thing disappear. What it does is loosen the loop. And the loop, almost always, is doing far more damage than the hard thing itself.

Three Words to Remember

The eagle has three qualities, and these three are what mindfulness actually feels like when it's real:

- **Curious.** Not panicked, not bored. Just genuinely interested in what's happening, the way the eagle is interested in the landscape below. *Hmm — what's actually here right now?*
- **Open.** No walls. You're willing to see things you didn't expect, including the parts of yourself you'd rather not look at.
- **Kind.** The eagle doesn't judge the city. It just watches. You let yourself, and everyone else, be human.

Curious. Open. Kind. If you remember nothing else from this chapter, remember those three.

And underneath all three, the deepest quality: the eagle just *watches*. It doesn't grasp. It doesn't try to hold on to the good views or push away the bad ones. It doesn't judge the landscape — calling this part pretty and that part ugly, then trying to keep one and get rid of the other. It just *sees* what's there. Good day, bad day, beautiful, ugly — each one passes through its field of vision and its fist never closes. That's the part almost everyone misses when they hear the word "mindfulness": it isn't about *capturing* the present moment. It's the opposite. It's the willingness to let each moment be exactly what it is — without fixing it, labeling it, keeping it, or pushing it away.

There's an old word from this whole tradition for that kind of seeing: **paramita**, which means something like *gone beyond*, or *transcendent*. The "beyond" is, mostly, beyond grasping. When mindfulness goes deep, it becomes a paramita — it lifts you beyond the small, anxious, gripping self into a wider sky where you can watch your life without having to clutch at it. That's what people are really reaching for when they get serious about this, even when they don't know the word for it.

Walking Meditation

Here is my favorite way to take mindfulness off the cushion and into your day. It's called **walking meditation**, and it is exactly what it sounds like: meditating *while you walk*. Slowly.

Find a path. A quiet hallway. A backyard. A short stretch of sidewalk. Even ten feet of bedroom will do. Stand still for a moment. Feel your feet on the ground, and notice your breath, coming in and going out. Then start to walk, much slower than your normal pace.

As you walk, let your attention rest on all of it at once — your breath, the soles of your feet, the swing of your arms, the air on your skin. If matching your steps to your breath feels natural — a few steps on the in-breath, a few on the out — go with that. Don't strain. Just *feel* what's happening, in detail: the lifting of one foot, the slow swing through the air, the placing back down on the ground, the shift of weight to that foot, and now the other foot lifting. The more closely you feel the details, the quieter your mind goes.

When your mind wanders — and it will, immediately — gently bring it back to the feeling of the steps, or the breath, or whichever sensation is most vivid right then. You're not trying to think anything in particular. You're just being the eagle, watching one foot in front of the other.

Try five minutes a day. It will change how you walk through every other part of your life.

And here's the part that turns walking meditation into something bigger than a five-minute exercise. Once you've practiced it formally a few times, you start to *remember* it anywhere. Walking home from school, walking the dog, walking from your kitchen to your bedroom — you'll catch yourself mid-step, slow your pace a beat, and feel your feet again. The whole world becomes your meditation hall the minute you remember it can be. Some of the clearest moments of my life have come on ordinary walks around the neighborhood, when I suddenly remembered to actually *be there* — feeling the breeze, hearing a bird I'd been walking right past for years, noticing the light through the leaves. You don't have to slow down dramatically. You just have to wake up to the walk you were already taking.

Mindfulness Is Not One More Thing

Hear this clearly, because it matters and almost no app will tell you: **mindfulness is not one more thing you have to add to your day.** It is, exactly, the opposite. It is *putting things down*.

The world will keep telling you mindfulness is about working harder on yourself, getting more disciplined, never losing focus. That's wrong. Mindfulness is about *unclenching*. It's the eagle taking off — not the eagle dragging more stones up into the air with it.

So start small. The one-minute reset from Chapter 7. The body scan from Chapter 5. Five minutes of walking. As one becomes natural, you'll *want* to add another — not because anyone is making you, but because you've noticed how much better the day is when you do. You add practices the way you'd add salt to food: a little at a time, until it tastes right. Never as a punishment. Always as a relief.

CHAPTER 11

11

Mantra — A Sound to Come Home To



Some days the mind is a hummingbird. It can't sit anywhere for more than a second; thoughts whip past so fast you can't even tell what they're about. On those days, even sitting in good posture and watching your breath might not be enough — the breath is too quiet, and your mind is too loud to land on it.

For days like that, people across just about every contemplative tradition on earth have found something that works: a **mantra**. A short sound, or a short phrase, that you repeat — silently, or under your breath — over and over, gently. The mantra becomes an anchor. When the hummingbird mind goes flying off, you don't chase it. You just come back to the sound. It's small. It's steady. It's always there.

This isn't unique to any one religion. Christians have prayers they repeat with beads. Muslims have *dhikr*, the practice of remembering by repeating a sacred name. The Jewish tradition has lines repeated for the same purpose. Hindu and Buddhist traditions have many. The shape of the practice is the same everywhere: a small, sacred sound to come home to when the mind has scattered.

It even shows up outside religion entirely. **Transcendental Meditation** — the practice you may have heard people like Jerry Seinfeld and Ray Dalio talk about — also uses a mantra. Each TM student is given their own particular sound by their teacher, kept private. I don't know what those sounds are, because I never took the course. The basic idea, though, is the same one we're working with here: a small, steady sound to come home to.

For this book, I'll give you one. Just one. It has been recited for more than a thousand years by more people, in more countries, than any other mantra on earth.

Om Mani Padme Hum

It is: **Om Mani Padme Hum.**

Say it slowly: *Ohm — mah-nee — pahd-may — hoom.*

Six syllables, originally from Sanskrit. The literal translation is something like *the jewel in the lotus*, but mantras aren't really about literal meaning the way a sentence is. They're more like *songs of the heart*. The way "amen" or "hallelujah" carry weight far beyond their dictionary definitions — that's how mantras work. Each of the six syllables is traditionally connected to a quality of kindness

and clear seeing. Together they point at something like: *the awake, kind heart is right here, even in the middle of the mud.* (You'll recognize the lotus from the last chapter. Same image.)

And there's one more piece worth knowing. This mantra belongs, in the tradition, to the great figure of compassion herself — known in China as **Guanyin**, in Tibet as **Chenrezig**, in Sanskrit as **Avalokiteshvara**. Across the Buddhist world, for more than a thousand years, people have turned to her in moments of trouble — asking for kindness, for healing, or simply for someone to be with them in their suffering. You don't have to believe in any of it for the mantra to help you; that isn't the point of saying it here. But knowing whose mantra it is gives you a sense of what it carries: an enormous, ancient river of human longing for kindness, flowing through six small syllables.

How to Use It

Sit in your seven points. Take a few slow breaths to arrive. Then, silently in your mind, begin to repeat: *Om Mani Padme Hum. Om Mani Padme Hum.* You can sync it to your breath if you like — half of it on the in-breath, half on the out. Or you can just let it go at its own slow pace, like a quiet heartbeat in the background.

When your mind wanders, don't get frustrated. Just notice that you wandered, and come back to the sound. That coming-back *is* the practice — every return is a small bow toward your own steadiness.

You can do this for two minutes or twenty. You can do it silently on the bus, while waiting in line, lying awake at three in the morning when your thoughts won't stop. Nobody around you will ever know.

One Last Thing

If Om Mani Padme Hum doesn't feel like yours, *any* short, kind phrase can do the same job. "*I'm here.*" "*Peace.*" "*All is well.*" A line of a poem you love. The point is not the magic of the particular words; the point is having one small, steady thing to come back to when everything else is spinning.

CHAPTER 12

12

Five Ways to Stay Out of Trouble



I want to share five simple guidelines for living. In Buddhism they're called the Five Precepts, but don't let that word scare you off — **these aren't a religious thing.** Some version of every one of them shows up in just about every culture, family, and circle of friends on Earth. They're just *smart*. They keep your life clean enough that your mind can actually be calm. (It's very hard to meditate peacefully when you've made a mess you're hiding.)

1. **Protect life; don't harm living things.** Be gentle with people, with animals, with the small creatures most people ignore. Cruelty makes the heart heavy. Kindness makes it light.

2. **Don't take what isn't yours.** Not things, not credit, not someone else's turn. Take only what's truly given.
3. **Be honest. Tell the truth.** Lies are exhausting to carry — you have to remember them and guard them forever. The truth is light. You can set it down.
4. **Treat your body and other people with respect.** Your body is yours; other people's bodies are theirs. Keep your friendships and relationships honest and kind, never using people or letting yourself be used. Respect goes both ways.
5. **Keep your mind clear — no alcohol, no drugs, nothing that fogs your thinking.** This one matters more than it might sound at twelve, and it'll matter more as you get older. Alcohol, vapes, weed, pills offered at a party, anything sold to you as a way to “feel better fast” — they all blur the very mind we've spent this whole book trying to wake up. They cloud your judgment exactly when you most need it sharp, and they quietly damage the only body you'll ever get. Saying no isn't being uptight or boring. It is an act of *self-respect* — of treating your own life as the precious, irreplaceable thing it is. A clear mind is the whole point. Don't trade it away cheaply.

Read them again. Not one of them is about belief. Every one of them is about staying free — free of guilt, free of messes, free to sit down at the end of the day with a quiet heart.

13

The Traps (What to Watch Out For)



Meditation is simple, but there are a few potholes in the road. Knowing about them ahead of time means you won't fall in.

Trap 1: Waiting for fireworks. You might sit and sit and feel... nothing special. Then you decide you're "bad at it" and quit. But meditation isn't supposed to feel like fireworks — and that includes hunting for a special glow, a buzz, or some inner light to "see." If a vision or a light ever does show up, it's just more scenery drifting past the window, not the destination. Most days are quiet and ordinary, and the ordinary days are *still working on you*, like exercise you can't feel building muscle. Don't judge a session by how exciting it was.

Trap 2: Thinking you have to empty your mind. This is the biggest myth. You will *never* have zero thoughts, and that's fine. The practice is not "no thoughts." The practice is *noticing* the thoughts — being the watcher. Every time you notice you got lost in thinking and you come back, that's not failing at meditation. **That's the whole exercise.** The coming-back is the rep.

Trap 3: Using it to run away. Meditation should help you face your feelings, not hide from them. If you ever notice you're "going calm" just to avoid dealing with something real — a problem with a friend, a feeling you don't want to feel — gently turn back toward the real thing. Calm is not for hiding.

Trap 4: Getting proud about it. Some people start to feel superior because they meditate — like they're more enlightened than everyone else. That's backwards. If meditation is making you look *down* on people, you've taken a wrong turn. The whole point (Chapter 4) is the opposite: the same light is in everyone underneath.

Trap 5: Forcing it. You can't grab calm by squeezing harder. Trying *too* hard makes you tense, which is the opposite of the goal. Hold it lightly, like a small bird in your hands — firm enough not to drop it, gentle enough not to crush it. And if a session ever starts to feel like genuinely *too much* — strong emotions surfacing, a sense of being flooded — that's another kind of forcing, the kind where you push past what's healthy. Stop. Open your eyes, get up, turn toward something engaged with the world (see Chapter 7 for what to do, and Chapter 4 for what kinds of things help). The cushion will still be there tomorrow.

Trap 6: Worshipping the symbols. This is a subtle one, and it matters to me. Beautiful statues, special cushions, fancy words, even teachers — all of it can be helpful. But none of it is *the thing itself*. Remember Chapter 6: anything you can see or hold is just a symbol, and symbols can be set down. If you ever catch yourself thinking the *object* is the magic — the special bead, the perfect playlist, the right outfit — gently let it go. The light was never in the object. It was always in you, the one who's seeing.

CHAPTER 14

14

Kindness Without Keeping
Score



Stop for a second and think about how you got through today.

The breakfast you ate was grown by farm workers you'll never meet — people who were up before dawn, working long hours in heat and cold for wages far too small. It was carried to you by drivers and delivery workers who sometimes can't even stop for a bathroom break. When you flip a switch, someone you'll never see is keeping the power on. And if you ever wake up sick and frightened in the middle of the night, there are nurses and doctors awake on that exact night shift, so that a stranger they have never met — you — can be okay.

None of them know your name. Most of them you will never lay eyes on. And still, your whole life — the food, the warmth, the safety, the hundred small comforts you barely notice — is being held up, every single hour, by thousands of quiet hands.

I want you to really feel that, *especially* on a day when it seems like nobody in the world cares whether you exist. Because here is something true even on that day: you are already being cared for, constantly, by more people than you could ever count. You are not as alone as the feeling tells you. You are woven into an enormous web of people quietly keeping each other alive — almost none of them ever thanked.

Once you really see that web, something in you wants to add your own thread to it. Not out of guilt — guilt is a miserable reason to do anything — but because it simply feels *right*. You've been carried; you find you want to help carry. That's just the natural shape of a heart that's paying attention.

And remember what we found earlier in this book: underneath everything, the same awake, aware light is in every person — in you, and in everyone. The farmer and the nurse and the delivery driver — but also the classmate who was cruel to you, and the grown-up who let you down — the same light is in all of them, underneath. Some people help the world in ways you can see, and some in ways you'll never know about. The person who quietly raises a child, or sweeps a floor, or simply gets through a brutal day without passing their pain on to anyone else, matters every bit as much as the famous face on a screen. There is no such thing as a small life. Every single one is precious. Every single one deserves to be protected. **Including yours.**

Now here's the part most people get wrong. They think kindness means giving and giving and then *waiting* — keeping a quiet scoreboard of who owes them back. That isn't kindness; it's a trade. And when the other person doesn't pay up the way you hoped, it breaks your heart every time.

Real kindness doesn't keep score.

It means you offer your care freely, and then you let go of what happens next. You don't grip it. You're kind because that's who *you* have decided to be — not because of what you'll get in return. The old teachers called this *kindness without attachment*, and it is one of the most freeing things a person can ever learn. When you stop *needing* people to respond a certain way, they lose the power to crush you by responding the wrong way. You stay soft. You're simply no longer breakable.

But — and this matters as much as anything in this whole book — **kindness without keeping score has to include being kind to yourself, and you start there.** You cannot pour from an empty cup. If you are running on empty, hurting, worn down to nothing, then the wisest and most loving thing you can do is turn some of that care *inward first*. Rest. Guard your own heart. And know this clearly: being kind to everyone does **not** mean letting anyone treat you badly. Sometimes the most compassionate thing you can do — for them *and* for you — is to take a step back, set down someone who keeps hurting you even if you still love them, and keep yourself safe. That is not unkindness. That is wisdom.

And now the hardest part of all.

Sometimes the people who are *supposed* to love you can't seem to manage it. A parent who won't show up. A friend who goes cold. People who turn away from you — maybe even for something about yourself that you finally found the courage to be honest about. When that happens, it doesn't feel like a disappointment; it feels like a verdict. *Something must be wrong with me.*

Please read this next sentence twice, because it's the most important one in the chapter: **when someone can't love you the way you deserve, that is news about where *they* are — not about whether *you* are lovable.**

People can only give from where they actually stand. Someone trapped in their own fear, their own anger, their own unhealed hurt, will sometimes push away the very people they love the most — not because those people aren't worth loving, but because the one doing the pushing is too lost, right then, to do any better. It's *their* cloud. It was never your light going out. Remember the sky behind the clouds — the sun doesn't dim just because a cloud rolls in front of it.

Grown-ups are not finished, perfect people. They make mistakes, sometimes enormous ones, sometimes the kind that wound their own kids. You're allowed to be angry about that. Your hurt is real and you never have to pretend it away. And — when *you* are ready, not a moment before — you can leave a quiet door open in your heart: maybe, given enough time, they'll find their way back, because people really do change, slowly, once they finally turn and face what they've been running from.

But hold on to this boundary, because it's the part that protects you: **it is not your job to fix them, and it is not your job to wait in pain for them.** You can wish them well from a safe distance. You can keep the door open without standing in the cold. And in the meantime, you turn toward the people who *can* show up for you right now — and there are some, even if they aren't the ones you most wish it could be. Let the people who are able to love you, love you.

One last thing, so you don't take this whole chapter and turn it into a heavy backpack you have to carry. You do not have to fix the world, or all of your broken relationships, today. That isn't how anything real works. The world's troubles are old and tangled; even the greatest helpers only ever move things forward a little at a time. People who try to fix *everything* at once tend to burn themselves out, or knock over things that were quietly holding other people up. Wanting good things doesn't automatically make you wise about how to get them — patience does. So go at a real pace. Protect yourself first. Do the kindness that's actually in front of you: a kind word, a hand to someone having a worse day than yours, simply not passing your pain down the line to the next person. That is not “too small.” That is *exactly* how the web grows stronger — one quiet thread at a time.

And the same goes for your own life. When you find something that genuinely interests you and doesn't hurt anyone, just *start*. You don't have to be sure it's the One True Calling — almost nobody is. Meaning grows up *through* the doing, the way a plant grows up through soil; you don't reason a tomato into existence, you plant a seed. Don't argue yourself out of your own life. Pick something small that feels true, and begin.

And if the sadness ever grows too heavy — heavier than you can carry alone, the kind that just won't lift — please remember that letting a caring grown-up help you carry it is itself an act of kindness toward yourself. You are not a burden. You are one of those precious, irreplaceable lives that deserve to be protected. You are worth helping, and asking for that help is one of the bravest, kindest things you will ever do.

You are held by a thousand hands you will never see. Add your one thread when you can. Protect your own light first. And be patient — with the world, with the people who couldn't, and most of all with yourself.

CHAPTER 15

15

Inner Joy, and the Days That Are Hard



I'll end where I began.

There is a light inside you — awake, warm, and quietly glad — and it does not go out. You already own it. Meditation is just walking back toward it, over and over, until you know the way even in the dark.

Some days will be hard. That's not a sign you're doing life wrong — it's just life. But here's what changes when you practice: the hard days stop being able to reach all the way down. You've got somewhere to stand. You find yourself noticing small joys you used to miss. You're kinder, because you've felt that the same light is in everyone. And you're tougher in a gentle way, because you know that storms pass and the sky stays.

If a hard day ever turns into a hard week, or a sadness sits on your chest and won't get up, please remember the lesson from the lost boy in Chapter 2: **tell a grown-up you trust**. Asking for help is not weakness. It is one of the strongest, wisest things a person can do — for kids and grown-ups alike.

And every day, big day or small, you can stop for one minute. Take one slow breath. Drop your shoulders. Become the eagle for a second and see your day from up there. If you've caught yourself in a loop, step out for a moment. Or just sit, and feel your breath move in and out, your shoulders soften, your feet on the floor.

That little *yes* in your chest, when you find it — that's the light that stays.